

ANI

HOME-GROWN STAR
BJP's Kangana Ranaut campaigning in Mandi with former CM Jai Ram Thakur (left), May 14

reduced red tapism, the government is committed to work for the people," he says. He accuses the BJP-led Centre of giving him insufficient funds for rehabilitation efforts after last year's floods. The other grouse against the BJP is, of course, the RS loss in February. "They have stolen a Rajya Sabha seat from me, I am seeking votes to take all four Lok Sabha seats," Sukhu tells INDIA TODAY.

Agnipath and Apples

The Congress is taking the fight to the BJP by targeting the Agnipath scheme in Kangra and Hamirpur—the belt known for high recruitment of youths in the military. With Himachal having 125,000 ex-servicemen and 115,000 men serving in the military, the practice of only 25 per cent Agniveers being absorbed is deeply unpopular. In the apple belt of Shimla, Mandi and Kangra, fruit growers are angry about cheaper imports from the US driving down prices and the inability of the Union government to levy higher anti-dumping duties. "I stand with apple growers...during the floods I ensured that road links were restored so they could send produce to markets," Sukhu says. However, with the Congress fielding former commerce minister Anand Sharma from Kangra, the BJP made the point that Sharma as Union minister had made a commitment to the WTO (World Trade Organization) to keep rates of this tariff at 50 per cent.

The BJP has fielded Rajiv Bhardwaj against Sharma. He replaces incumbent MP Krishan Kapoor—who excused himself after being diagnosed with cancer—thus marking the end of his mentor and former CM Shanta Kumar's influence in Himachal. Union minister Anurag Thakur will again fight from Hamirpur, while former state BJP chief Suresh Kashyap got the ticket in Shimla. The Congress has fielded its MLA from Kasauli, Vinod Sultanpuri, to take on Kashyap. Former MLA Satpal Raizada is its Hamirpur candidate.

Anurag Thakur, the four-time MP from Hamirpur, also has to ensure victories for Congress turncoats Inder Dutt Lakhanpal (Barsar), Devender Bhutto (Kutlehar), Rajendra Rana (Sujanpur) and Chaitanya Sharma (Gagret) in the bypolls—all in his constituency—on BJP tickets. The other two Congress turncoats from the February episode, Ravi Thakur and Sudhir Sharma, are contesting from Lahaul Spiti (in Mandi LS seat) and Dharamshala (Kangra).

Though Hamirpur is a saffron bastion, the BJP lost 12 out of 17 assembly seats here in 2022 due to factionalism. This time, it hopes a nationalist agenda and an active Anurag would help it retain the seat. With the assembly constituency of CM Sukhu (Nadaun) also part of Hamirpur, the Congress is telling voters about the BJP plot to dislodge the local boy from the CM's post. In Shimla, Congress candidate Sultanpuri is trying hard to make it a Congress bastion, like it was during his father's prime. In 2022, out of 17 assembly segments here, Congress won 13.

'Queen' vs 'King'

Fielding actor Kangana Ranaut in Mandi is working out well for the BJP. With her aggression and star power, she has made an instant connect with the electorate, also helped by her being fluent in the Mandyali accent. Indeed, in Mandi and Kullu districts, she has the persona of a local girl who made it big in Bollywood. The BJP has asked Jai Ram Thakur to anchor her campaign. "We had lost the bypoll (in 2021) narrowly. Now...there is no sympathy wave (after Congress CM Virbhadra Singh's death)," the former CM claims. Thakur is influential in Mandi, and in 2022, half of the BJP's legislative strength came from here. The stakes are high for him—he knows that his chances of being CM again depend on a favourable outcome.

Kangana is taking on Vikramaditya Singh, son of Pratibha Singh and former CM Virbhadra Singh, in his family bastion. Vikramaditya, the titular 'king' of Rampur Bushahr, is conducting a low-profile campaign. In February, he, too, had joined the rebellion and quit the Sukhu cabinet, claiming the government did nothing to preserve his father's legacy, before being persuaded to continue. Ironically, as Sukhu tries to seek votes for Congress candidates by pointing at the BJP's efforts to destabilise his government, Vikramaditya is trying to convince voters to safeguard his family legacy.

Amid these smaller battles, the bigger war for the Congress is to ensure their government lasts the whole term. A few Lok Sabha seats would be more than welcome too. ■